

SEA OF UNCERTAINTY

Playbook, Examples, Scenarios, and Designer Notes

BOOK III - PLAYBOOK

Development Manuscript v0.6

Operational naval warfare under conditions of incomplete information

Source baseline: public Sea of Uncertainty repository, current Prototype Rules v0.5, Design Constitution v0.3, and Design Notes.

This manuscript reorganizes source-supported rules into professional regulatory prose. Proposed or unresolved material is explicitly marked.

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A.0 HOW TO LEARN THE GAME

A.1 First Session

Use only the Core Rules. Limit each side to four Formations and keep initial Contacts simple. The first teaching goal is not to master every modifier; it is to understand how a Formation becomes Ready, chooses an Action, accepts a risk/reward posture, resolves, and receives a new Ready Time.

A.2 Learning Order

1. Move and Ready Time.
2. Search and Contact quality.
3. Strike and defender Reaction.
4. Entropy and Recovery.
5. Command Attention and Push Through.
6. Synchronization.
7. Response Cards and Deception.
8. Only then add selected Advanced Rules.

TEACHING PRINCIPLE: The player aid should answer the repeated questions: What do I know? What can I do? What is the reward? What is the risk? When will I be Ready again?

B.0 EXTENDED EXAMPLE OF PLAY

B.1 Situation

Blue must protect an amphibious transit through a central sea corridor. Blue controls CSG-71, SAG-12, SSN-8, and Air Group 4. Red controls an equivalent carrier group, SAG, submarine, and land-based air group. Both sides have 3 Command Slots and 3 Response Cards.

B.2 Time 06 - Blue Search Decision

CSG-71 is Ready at 06. Blue possesses a Medium-Location, General-Identity Contact two hexes west, Age 1. Blue could Strike immediately at -1 Targeting, Move to improve geometry, Hold to preserve concealment, or Search. Blue selects Focused Search, committing one Command Slot. Search 3 + Focused 2 + target Signature 1 - range 2 = 4. The roll succeeds and Blue improves Location to High. The Contact refreshes to Age 0. CSG-71 becomes Ready at 08.

WHY IT MATTERS: Blue did not win information for free. Red may act at Time 07 before CSG-71 can exploit the improved fix.

B.3 Time 07 - Red High-Tempo Move

Red SAG is Ready at 07 and moves High Tempo three hexes toward the amphibious route. It gains +1 Signature and suffers a Friction event. Red draws a Friction Effect Card and attaches it. The SAG becomes easier to find and may carry a specific operational problem even though it reached a threatening position quickly.

B.4 Time 08 - Blue Strike or Synchronize

CSG-71 is Ready with a High-Location Contact. Blue can Strike now, or wait for SSN-8 and Air Group 4. A synchronized operation could reduce Red Defense on subsequent attacks, but the Contact will continue to age and Red may move again. Blue chooses to wait for Time 09, assigns one Command Slot to Synchronization, and risks the target moving.

B.5 Defender Reaction

At the synchronized Strike, Red chooses Defend for the first attack, gaining +1 Defense. If Red instead selected Counterattack, it would forgo the Defense bonus but could return a Light Strike if it survived. The Reaction decision is made before the Combat Band is finalized.

B.6 Entropy Accumulation

If three independent Blue Formations participate, each suffers a Friction event. Even a tactically successful attack can leave the attacking force operationally less coherent, producing a meaningful decision about Recovery on later Ready Times.

C.0 TUTORIAL SCENARIO FRAMEWORK

C.1 Map

Recommended teaching map: approximately 12 x 10 operational hexes with one central route, one or two Littoral/chokepoint features, and at least one objective that rewards positioning rather than destruction.

C.2 Forces

Each side: 1 carrier group, 1 surface action group, 1 submarine, and 1 air group. Keep Formation ratings intentionally asymmetric so players must use Support and posture rather than mirror tactics.

C.3 Victory

Blue wins by moving a protected transit through the central corridor while retaining a combat-capable carrier. Red wins by preventing transit or forcing the protected force to withdraw. Avoid awarding primary points for individual ship kills.

C.4 Information Setup

Begin with at least one ambiguous Contact and one False Contact so the Search system matters immediately.

D.0 OPERATIONAL DECISION EXAMPLES

D.1 High Tempo or Cautious?

High Tempo gains two additional hexes over Cautious but increases Signature and creates Friction. The right choice depends on whether arriving sooner is worth becoming easier to find and risking a specific Friction manifestation.

D.2 Active or Focused Search?

Active Search improves detection without consuming Command Attention but makes the Formation Loud. Focused Search improves Search more and preserves the ordinary Signature state but occupies scarce headquarters attention.

D.3 Strike Now or Synchronize?

An immediate Strike preserves tempo and reduces Contact aging risk. Synchronization may overwhelm defenses but spends Command Attention, delays participants, and can create Friction.

D.4 Recover or Press On?

Recovery removes a specific Friction/Disruption manifestation, but costs 2 Time. Pressing on preserves tempo while leaving the Formation operationally degraded.

D.5 Defend or Counterattack?

Defend improves survival now. Counterattack sacrifices that defensive bonus for the possibility of immediate retaliation if the Formation survives.

E.0 ENTROPY AND CARD PLAY

E.1 Why Cards Exist

Entropy cards are not a random event deck that fires independently of player choices. A decision or enemy effect first causes an Entropy event; the card then specifies how that already-earned disorder manifests.

E.2 Entropy Suites

Friction cards emphasize execution, timing, coordination, and operational workload. Disruption cards emphasize information, sensors, communications, and command. Destruction cards emphasize specific physical losses.

E.3 Response Cards

Response Cards reverse the agency relationship. They are held player options, not random penalties. The player decides whether a problem is important enough to spend the card and accept any printed Cost.

E.4 Current Component Count

The current design contains 36 Entropy Effect Cards - 12 each Friction, Disruption, Destruction - and 24 Command Response Cards.

CARD DESIGN TEST: A good card should create or sharpen a decision. A bad card simply says that something unfortunate happened with no meaningful response.

F.0 PLAYTEST PROTOCOL

F.1 Record These Moments

- Every time a player says an Action is obvious.

- Every repeated rule lookup.
- Every inactive-player lull.
- Every die result that feels stronger than the preparation that created the band.
- Every Action never chosen.
- Every Action chosen almost automatically.
- Every time Contact Age changes a decision.
- Every time a Command Slot feels painfully scarce.
- Every time Recovery is tempting but operationally costly.

F.2 Post-Game Questions

1. What was your hardest decision?
2. What decision do you regret most?
3. When did you lack enough information?
4. When did you wish you had one more Command Slot?
5. Did you delay to synchronize, and was it worth it?
6. Did you Recover when you wanted to keep fighting?
7. Did map maneuver feel genuinely naval?
8. Did combat create enough drama?
9. Can you explain the outcome mostly through decisions rather than dice?

G.0 RULES DEVELOPMENT LEDGER

Issue	Current Status	Recommended Home
Same-Time priority	Conflicting source text	Core reconciliation
Move rating integration	Underdefined	Advanced Movement
Support range/stacking	Underdefined	Advanced Support
Age-2 targeting penalty	Optional	Advanced Contact Aging / scenario
Light Damage	Underdefined	Advanced Damage
Complex Action	Undefined term	Advanced Complex Actions
HQ Recovery	Referenced only	Advanced Command

Logistics Access	Undefined	Advanced Logistics
Repair/Reorganization	Underdefined	Advanced Repair
Response draw schedule	Underdefined	Advanced Response Cards
Air Operations	Abstract	Advanced Air
Submarine/ASW	Abstract	Advanced Sub/ASW
Layered missile defense	Not core	Advanced Combat
Endurance trigger	Provisional	Advanced Endurance

H.0 DESIGN CONSTITUTION

- Agency before procedure.
- Playable verbs before theory.
- Detail must create decisions.
- Every strong option carries a cost.
- Luck reflects decisions.
- Physical warfare remains tangible.
- Time is a resource.
- Information is imperfect, stale, and contestable.
- Command Attention is finite.
- Entropy is core, but never generic morale.
- Cohesion summarizes Entropy.
- Every subsystem should speak the same mechanical language.
- The Sequence of Play should teach the game.
- The system should support layers of mastery.
- Operational skill should matter more than stat optimization.
- Playtesting is part of design.

I.0 DESIGNER NOTES: PERLA-INSPIRED PRINCIPLES

I.1 Six Dimensions

The conceptual foundation treats time, space, forces, effects, information, and command as interacting dimensions. Sea of Uncertainty turns them into concrete player-facing systems rather than separate theoretical chapters.

I.2 Time and Friction

Ready Time makes temporal opportunity part of the board state. Friction primarily damages schedules rather than merely applying generic negative modifiers.

I.3 Information

The Contact system creates different realities: actual position, Blue's believed picture, and Red's believed picture. Age prevents one successful Search from permanently solving uncertainty.

I.4 Command

Standing Missions let formations execute without constant activation. Command Attention is spent when the player wants to intervene, synchronize, force, or focus.

I.5 Entropy

Entropy is treated as unavailable military potential rather than morale. Specific cards show why that capability is unavailable.

I.6 Synchronization

Synchronization is powerful because effects arrive inside the defender's recovery/reaction window. The system therefore rewards timing without granting a simple generic combined-arms bonus.

DESIGNER NOTE: The source framework informs the model, but Sea of Uncertainty remains an original board-game design. The purpose of the printed rules is to make these ideas playable, not to teach the theory before a player can move or shoot.

J.0 PROFESSIONAL PUBLICATION CHECKLIST

- Every defined term capitalized consistently or intentionally lower-case.
- Every timing window stated explicitly.
- Every modifier declares whether it stacks.
- Every card timing references a rules window.
- Every scenario lists Advanced Rules in force.
- All Design Holds removed or relocated to development notes.
- All tables cross-checked against Player Aid.

- Examples use the same numbers as the final tables.
- Index includes key concepts and card terms.
- Sequence of Play appears on the back cover/player aid.
- Component manifest matches card counts and punchboards.
- Print layout separates Rules, Examples, Designer Notes, and Optional Rules visually.

PUBLICATION TARGET: A finished edition should let a new player learn the Core from Book I and the Player Aid, while experienced players can layer Book II modules without rewriting the base game.